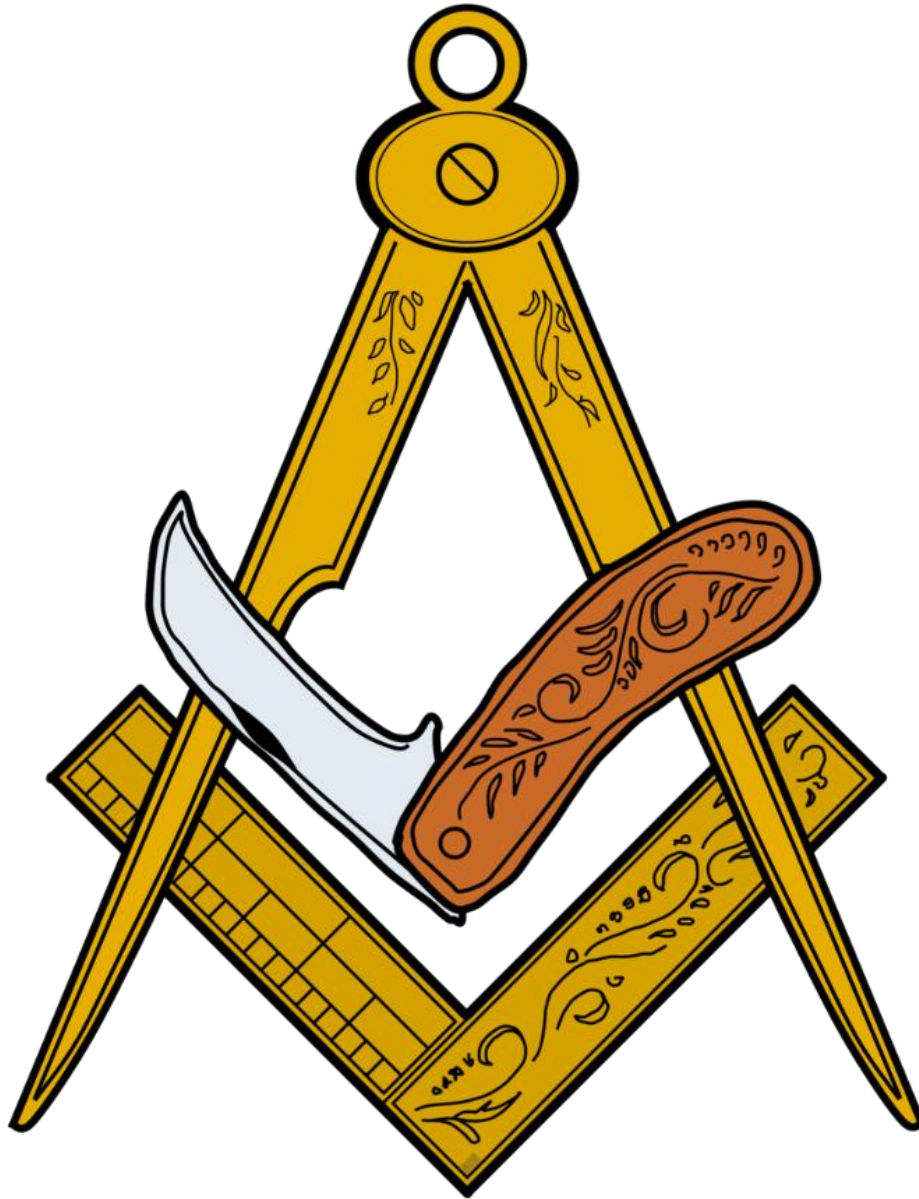


FIRST DEGREE LECTURE

THE FREE GARDENER APPRENTICE



[Authorized by the United Council, A.O.F.G., Inc.]

The Arrangement of the Garden [the Lodge]

In the Free Gardenery, we typically speak of *ceremonies*—not *rituals*. The German language, however, doesn't recognize the word “ceremonial.” The word *ritual* comes from the Latin *ritualis*, meaning “pertaining to the rite.” Both terms—*ceremonial* and *ritual*—only became common in German during the 18th century. The ceremonial customs in the Market Garden were adopted around 1700 from the French word *cérémonial*, which carries the same meaning. *Ceremonial* refers to the set of established behaviors, manners, and rules followed during a social ceremony.

This is exactly how metaphorical gardening—our term for ceremonial gatherings—should be understood: dignified, festive, and conducted in accordance with prescribed behavior. Decorum is essential not only for the Worthy Master, who sets the tone, rhythm, and pace, but also for all keepers. Each participant must come prepared and strive to offer their best during a metaphorical gardening session.

Nothing in Free Gardener ceremonies is arbitrary or coincidental. The garden is always rectangular in shape, determined by the positioning of the keepers (officers). The distance between the Worthy Master and the Emissary Master is always greater than the space between the tables of the Secretary and Chaplain and those of the Rentmaster and Instruction Master. Within this outer rectangular garden—our lodge—lies an inner square garden, symbolic of paradise.

Let's begin by examining this square garden. Its arrangement corresponds to a Greek cross, with four beams of equal length. This structure takes into account the placement of the tables for the Worthy Master, the Secretary and Chaplain, the Rentmaster and Instruction Master, and the “Altar in the West.” At the center of this cross is the archetype specific to the degree. For the Apprentice Degree, that archetype is the snake.

Only one table in the garden is considered an altar: the one beneath the unadorned rose arch. This altar symbolizes Noah's altar, which he built after the flood (Genesis 8:20), and is known as the “Altar in the West” or “Western Altar.” The table of the Worthy Master, located in the east, is *not* an altar—a distinction made clear by its equal height to the other tables. It remains level with the rest of the furnishings and, by extension, with all brothers and sisters.

On the Altar in the West—within the square garden—are placed *The Four Parables of Paradise*, often simply called *The Four Parables*.

	1st degree	2nd degree	3rd degree	4th degree
The Four Parables	Pink Rose	White Rose	Red Rose	Olive Branch
Symbolic Meaning	Faith	Hope	Love	Fulfillment

The Worthy Master sits in the East, the Secretary and the Chaplain in the North, and the Rentmaster and the Instruction Master in the South.

On the green working carpet lie the three Tools of the West: the spade, rake, and scythe. These are not explicitly referenced during the ceremony of the Apprentice Degree, as all participants are presumed to be familiar with their practical function in the art of gardening.

At the table of the Worthy Master rest the three **Tools of the East**: the compass, square, and pruning knife.

	1st Degree	2nd Degree	3rd degree	4th degree
The Four Great Lights	Compass	Square	Pruning Knife	Bible
Tools of the East	Compass	Square	Pruning Knife	
Tools of the West	Spade	Rake	Scythe	
Spiritual Virtues	Faith	Hope	Love	Fulfilment

The correspondence between the tools of the East and West is subtle yet meaningful: the *compass* mirrors the *spade*, the *square* aligns with the *rake*, and the *pruning knife* complements the *scythe*.

In the Apprentice Degree of the Free Gardeners, it is stated:

"The compass is the tool of God the Creator, who conceives, develops, shapes, and creates the world with the stroke of a compass."

The compass is a symbol of *faith*, and while central to the Free Gardener, it is as essential in its domain as the spade is to the operative gardener.

Likewise, the ceremony declares:

"The square is the tool by which the Supreme Gardener of the Universe measures and judges the actions of man."

It stands as a symbol of *hope* and serves the Free Gardener as the rake does the operative gardener.

And further, it is written:

"The pruning knife is the gardener's simplest tool and the Free Gardener's highest ornament. With it, the Supreme Gardener of the Universe intervenes in Creation."

The pruning knife represents *love* and is no less vital to the Free Gardener than the scythe is to the operative.

These three Tools of the East—the *compass*, *square*, and *pruning knife*—alongside the Bible, form the **Four Great Lights of Free Gardening**, with the Bible regarded as the greatest among them.

The square form of the inner Paradise Garden draws symbolic inspiration from monastic courtyards, which traditionally feature a central fountain and four symmetrical paths. These paths represent the four rivers of Eden: *Pishon*, *Gihon*, *Hiddekel* (Tigris), and *Euphrates*. This vision is explicitly reflected in our garden's design.

At the beginning of metaphorical garden work in the Apprentice Degree, there are no letters on the green working carpet, as creation, in the biblical sense, has not yet appeared. Free Gardening, however, affirms a pre-existing creation, thereby rejecting the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo*—creation out of nothing. The unfolding of biblical creation takes place during the initiation.

Creation becomes tangible only once the initials *P*, *G*, *H*, and *E*—representing the four rivers—are placed on the working carpet. These rivers flow outward from the center of the Paradise Garden.

During the opening of the metaphorical garden work in the Apprentice Degree, creation remains situated within the fifth day of the biblical account. Through the actions of the opening ceremony, creation is reenacted from the first to the fifth day, making both the garden and creation manifest—both previously unseen.

New Free Gardener Apprentices sit in the **northeast**, in a place of *obscured luminescence* (*bright darkness*). There must always be space reserved for them. It is the responsibility of the Instruction Master to ensure this as sisters and brothers enter the garden.

When alone in the garden, the Instruction Master must never cross the axis connecting the Worthy Master and the Altar in the West. He must walk only in the western portion—between the Altar in the West and the Emissary Master’s table—so as not to break this sacred alignment. This protocol also applies to lodge members exiting the garden; they follow their side paths westward to the exit.

Because apprentices sit in the northeast, they usually enter through the north. The ceremonial aprons distributed during the initiation are also placed in the northeast, near the Worthy Master’s table. In the first and third degrees, the Secretary assists in distributing these vestments; in the second and fourth, the Rentmaster takes that role.

The Worthy Master, Secretary, Chaplain, Rentmaster, and Instruction Master serve as the **inner keepers** of the square Paradise Garden. The Instruction Master is the only one among them permitted to move between the square inner garden and the outer rectangular lodge.

Meanwhile, the Emissary Master, Keyholder, and Gatekeeper serve as the **outer keepers**, situated outside the square Paradise Garden but still within the rectangular lodge.

All ceremonial roles are designated as *keepers*, a title inspired by the Hebrew word **S-----**, meaning “-- ----,” and a reference to the first Free Gardener and Keeper: ----.

With the placement of the Worthy Master’s table, the Greek cross formed by the garden becomes a **Latin cross**—its vertical axis extending westward. Symbolically, this expansion is crucial. Without it, the Garden of Paradise would remain forever inaccessible. This extension—referred to as the *lodge*—provides a pathway, as stated:

“The Lord God took the man out of the Garden of Eden to till the soil from which he had been taken. So He drove out Adam and placed the cherubim at the entrance of Eden with a flaming sword to guard the way to the Tree of Life.” (Genesis 3:20–24)

The Emissary Master, by name and function, represents the Paradise Garden. His duty is to examine and instruct seekers, determining their worthiness to enter. He is assisted by the Keyholder and the Gatekeeper. The Keyholder guards the *inner gate*; the Gatekeeper guards the *outer gate*.

The Gatekeeper alone may cross the threshold between the outer and inner worlds. The Instruction Master alone may move between the square Paradise Garden and the rectangular lodge.

Symbolically, the Gatekeeper is the **outer psychopomp**—the soul’s guide between realms. The Instruction Master serves as the **inner psychopomp**—the guide within the lodge and the Garden of Paradise.

The Task of the Instruction Master

In the Order of Free Gardeners, those who perform a ceremony are not called officials or officers, but *keepers*. The Worthy Master—one of eight keepers required for initiation—explains during the Free Gardener Apprentice Catechism at the conclusion of the metaphorical gardening ceremony:

My esteemed brothers and sisters, I will now further induct you into our community as Free Gardener-Apprentice. This lowest degree is the humblest but also the most honorable of all degrees. We call it the Degree of the Keeper. That is why the Hebrew word S----- was chosen as a motto, which means “—k---”, and refers to the word of this degree, ---- (Genesis 2:15). The word and motto of this degree together means “---- k----” or “---- t----”.

The role of the keepers is inspired by Adam, the first ancestor of the Free Gardeners, as Genesis 2:15 states:

“And the Lord God took the man and put him in the Garden of Eden to tend and keep it.”

However, when the lights are lit during the ceremony, it is Genesis 2:8 that is recited instead:

“And the Lord God planted a garden in Eden, in the east, and placed there the man He had formed.”

At this moment, the seeker is accepted as a Free Gardener Apprentice but is not yet named a keeper. This stage is unique: as the Chaplain reads Genesis 2:8 aloud, the Instruction Master stands between the snake depicted on the working carpet and the kneeling seeker.

After removing the seeker’s blindfold, the Instruction Master places both hands on their shoulders and says:

“Beware of temptation and the wiles of the evil one.”

At this critical moment, few realize the act of strength and love being performed—for both the seeker and the community [lodge]. What is this temptation? What are these wiles? All present, except for the newly accepted seekers, will later recall the passage read by the Chaplain—the story of Paradise, in which the snake tempts Eve with fruit from the Tree of Knowledge (Genesis 3:1–7).

It is worth noting that the Order speaks of *first through fourth degrees of admission*, since members do not abandon earlier degrees—they embody them. This reveals the equality of all degrees and emphasizes that none should be omitted. Without all four, the teachings of Free Gardening remain fragmented.

In that moment, the Instruction Master consciously stands between the archetype of the Apprentice Degree—the *snake*—and the seeker. Every Free Gardener [Master] has made the following vow:

“To support, encourage and protect our brothers and sisters whenever possible. To strive earnestly, sincerely, and zealously, for the Friendship of every member.”

The Instruction Master's actions exemplify that vow in the clearest terms.

There is another layer to this moment. The snake gave Adam and Eve unrestricted access to knowledge—without teaching, guidance, or protection. Overwhelmed, they were banished from the Garden of Paradise so they would not perish from spiritual confusion and thirst. During the ceremony, following the reading of Genesis 3:7:

“Then the eyes of both of them were opened, and they realized they were naked; so they sewed fig leaves together and made coverings [KJV - aprons] for themselves.”

It is essential that seekers *put on their own aprons*. In this symbolic act, the Instruction Master shields the seeker from the temptation to grasp all knowledge at once or to be misled—what today might be called “misinformation” or “fake news.” He defends them from the cunning of the evil one—not from evil itself, but from those misleading influences that sever access to the Tree of Life.

That is why the terms “temptation” and “wiles of the evil one” are used deliberately.

In all ceremonies, seekers are addressed formally by their full names and always referred to as *seekers*.

The Instruction Master is the only Keeper permitted to walk between the inner square (Paradise Garden) and the outer rectangle (lodge). In doing so, he performs a solemn act of love. The safeguard against false or overwhelming knowledge is found in the *four virtues* of Free Gardening.

- The **first degree** represents *love*, for the path begins in love.
- The **second degree** embodies *wisdom*.
- The **third degree** teaches *harmony*.
- The **fourth degree** reveals *truth*.

This progression explains why, in later degrees, the rose arch is opened and the Altar in the West changes location. It symbolizes that, through the teachings of Free Gardening, one regains access to Paradise. By applying these teachings, one may approach the Tree of Knowledge with reverence and eat from the Tree of Life without falling into hubris.

As Revelation 22:2 states:

“down the middle of the great street of the city. On each side of the river stood the tree of life, bearing twelve crops of fruit, yielding its fruit every month. And the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations.”

Free Gardener Masters will recognize the significance of *healing* in this passage. Apprentices, too, may rediscover its meaning in the catechism, which speaks indirectly of physical, mental, spiritual, and divine healing.

In Paradise, humanity was perfect and fed daily from the Tree of Life, never facing death. Only after eating from the Tree of Knowledge—according to “The Story of the Very First Free Gardener”—did thorns and thistles arise: the gardener’s greatest burden. God expelled man from Eden so the garden could be restored to its perfect state. Though humanity was separated from its home, the longing to return—and for its lost perfection—persisted and grew over generations.

The Gatekeeper is the only Keeper permitted to pass between the inner and outer worlds. This banishment was not a denial of divinity, but a protective act. Knowledge must be gained through love, wisdom, harmony, and truth—not through cunning or temptation.

As Genesis 3:22–23 reminds us:

“And the LORD God said, “The man has now become like one of us, knowing good and evil. He must not be allowed to reach out his hand and take also from the tree of life and eat, and live forever. So, the LORD God banished him from the Garden of Eden to work the ground from which he had been taken.”

The lesson is clear: knowledge gained through deception brings painful consequences. It echoes life’s relationships—those built on dishonesty, temptation, or falsehood cannot thrive. Instead, they lead to the banishment of one’s own heart.

Everything Is Equal and Preexistent

When the seeker—our ceremonial term for candidates of initiation—is led into the garden, certain preparations have already taken place, though the seeker remains unaware. Before the metaphorical garden work begins, every detail is carefully arranged. The keepers have assumed their positions, and all members stand as the sisters and brothers enter—without any ceremonial gestures or signs.

Although the Worthy Master sets the tone, pace, and rhythm, all keepers are regarded as equals. Those entering must take their seats immediately. Only once everyone is seated does the Worthy Master instruct the keepers to sit. This action is the ceremony’s first symbolic gesture of equality, as the Worthy Master and the keepers lower themselves to the same level as the gathered brotherhood. This moment is often highlighted with a musical accompaniment.

Throughout the ceremony, the equality of all roles and actions is reaffirmed. Every table, including the “Altar in the West” beneath the rose arch, is placed at the same height—none stands elevated. One of the earliest pivotal moments in the ceremony is the collective opening of the metaphorical garden lodge. All must be present and participate; the garden work cannot proceed otherwise.

The Keepers are already positioned in the garden from the outset, and nothing is enacted that contradicts the principle of preexistent creation. In this instance, Free Gardening rejects the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo*—the belief in creation out of nothing. Instead, the spiritual and earthly unfolding of creation manifests during the initiation ceremony, and only through the presence and witness of the community [lodge].

Preexistent creation continues only once initiation has begun and the distribution of light has taken place—marked by the removal of the blindfold, which is the sole mental and physical distinction between seeker and initiate. In keeping with the biblical narrative, the ceremony situates itself just before the sixth day of creation, as the letter “A”—for Adam, first referencing the androgynous [and primordial] Adam Kadmon (Ah-dahm Kahd-mohn)—is placed upon the working carpet.

As participants enter the garden before the ceremonial opening, creation is considered to have reached the fifth day. Therefore, no consecration or blessing of the space is necessary—everything needed is already present.

Nature, in Free Gardening, is regarded as self-sufficient. This flexibility is among the Order’s strengths: wherever Free Gardeners gather, a lodge may be convened. Coordination with the mother lodge is usually expected, but formal consecration of the space is unnecessary. The collective action of those present is itself the consecration.

The Fifth Day of Creation

According to Genesis 1:1–23 (NIV), by the fifth day, the heavens, earth, celestial bodies, vegetation, and living creatures have all been created:

"So God created the great creatures of the sea and every living thing with which the water teems and that moves about in it... And God saw that it was good... And there was evening, and there was morning—the fifth day." (Genesis 1:21, 23)

Only humanity, created on the sixth day, is not yet present. In this ceremony, however, the Keepers and the gathered brotherhood serve as a prefiguration of humanity—a symbolic preparation for its full emergence during initiation. In Kabbalistic tradition, this prefiguration is called Adam Kadmon, and it reflects the ideal role each Free Gardener is called to fulfill.

Every Free Gardener, not just the Worthy Master or Keepers, is a reflection of their highest potential—a living embodiment of the best within.

The Mythic Foundation

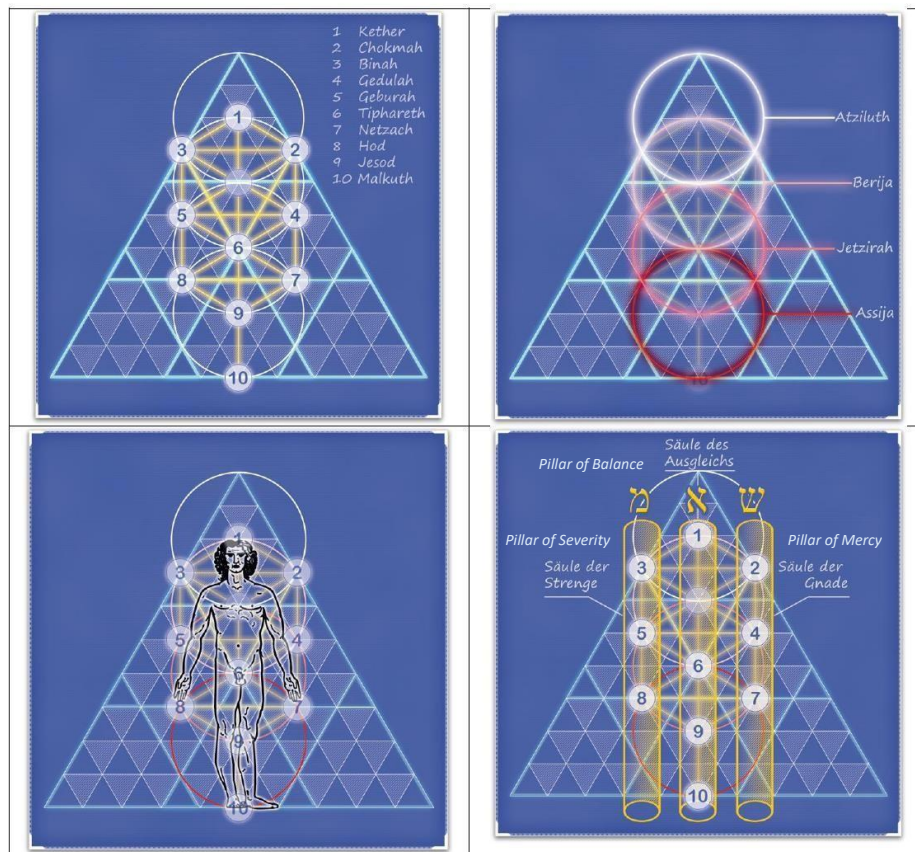
The four-degree system of Free Gardening is rooted in Kabbalah. The Supreme Gardener of the Universe—our name for God—created Adam Kadmon from His own essence and in His image. Adam Kadmon was the first emanation of divine light, the template of all existence. Later, in a second narrative of paradise, Adam is formed from clay.

What takes place in the cosmos—the “above”—is reflected here on earth—the “below.” Thus, Adam Kadmon is the divine blueprint in the heavens, and the earthly Adam is the living expression of that blueprint in the material realm.

The light from which Adam Kadmon was fashioned resides, in part, within every living being. This truth is ceremonially revealed through the removal of the blindfold. There are, in fact, two creation stories in Genesis:

- The first (Genesis 1) describes the creation of Adam Kadmon—a being of light.
- The second (Genesis 2) presents Adam formed from clay—the earthly human.

Both figures are originally androgynous. Only in the second narrative, as Adam becomes material, are male and female distinguished.



A Brief Note on the Order of Creation

If the letters of the four Paradise rivers were placed on the working carpet *before* the letter “A” (for Adam), then creation would be symbolically complete at the moment the brotherhood enters. This would compromise our identity as an order rooted in charitable work and honorable principles—principles expressed by the maxim, “*Treat others as you wish to be treated.*”

Such premature placement would diminish our longing for unity with the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, shifting our balance toward a more exoteric stance. As it stands now, Free Gardening preserves an essential equilibrium between esotericism and exotericism.

Immediately after the chaplain places the “A” on the working carpet, a passage from the *second* creation narrative is read. While the *first* creation account (Genesis 1) concerns the cosmos, creation, and the androgynous human, the *second* narrative (Genesis 2) presents a more intimate view—focusing on Paradise and humanity. At this point, the chaplain places the four river letters on the working carpet. These rivers appear only in the second account, and their symbolism aligns with the themes of Paradise, growth, and spiritual readiness.

During ceremonial instruction in the First Degree, the working carpet is prepared precisely in this sequence.

Once everything is properly in place, the Free Gardener Apprentice—now without the blindfold—may approach the Master's table with full awareness and take their oath. From this moment onward, the initiate is equipped to resist temptation and deceit. The seeker has become enlightened.